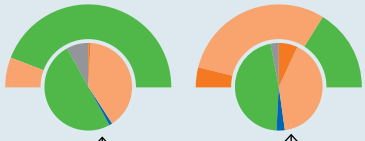
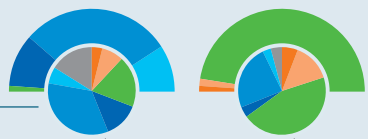
ANDHRA PRADESH 25



	2019	2014
BJP	0 (1%)	2 (7%)
TDP	3 (40%)	15 (41%)
Cong.	0 (1%)	0 (3%)
YSRCP	22 (50%)	8 (46%)
Others	0 (8%)	0 (3%)

Note: TDP was not a BJP ally in 2019

TAMIL NADU 39



	2019	2014
BJP	0 (4%)	1 (6%)
Allies	0 (8%)	1 (14%)
AIADMK	1 (19%)	37 (45%)
Cong.	8 (13%)	0 (4%)
DMK	23 (34%)	0 (24%)
Allies	7 (6%)	0 (3%)
Others	0 (16%)	0 (4%)

Note: The Congress was not part of the DMK-led alliance in 2014. The AIADMK was part of the NDA in 2019

in 2019, but has teamed up with actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party. The BJP will be contesting just six seats under the banner of the NDA, but hopes to possibly open its own account while gaining from the numbers of its alliance partners. It will be a tough ask, given that they are ranged against the formidable Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) leader and Chief Minister Jagan Reddy. With the assembly election being held simultaneously, Jagan is putting up the fight of his life to win a second term.

In Karnataka, the BJP's lone outpost in the South till now where it lost the plot and was worsted by the Congress in the summer assembly poll of 2023, the party has moved with alacrity to make amends. To retain its 2019 tally of 25 seats, it has tied up with another old ally, the Janata Dal Secular (JDS), headed by former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy, son of former prime minister Deve Gowda. Not only has the BJP conceded three seats to the JD(S) in its Vokkaliga stronghold to thwart the Congress, but also revamped the party organisation by making B.Y. Vijayendra, son of former chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa, president of the state unit, to win over the sizeable Lingayat vote that had been unhappy with Yediyurappa's removal in 2021 and had backed the Congress in the assembly election. The party is also pinning its hopes on PM Modi's popularity to give it a decisive push and cut the ascendant Congress in the state. Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has delivered on the guarantees the party had promised and is looking to win more than the one seat his party won in 2019.

ACCORDING TO PSEPHOLOGIST YASHWANT DESHMUKH, THE BJP'S VOTE SHARE COULD RISE BUT IT MAY NOT CONVERT INTO MORE SEATS. IT'S A LONG-TERM GAME FOR THE PARTY

Missing a Trick

Ditto in Telangana, where the Congress edged out the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) led by the charismatic A. Revanth Reddy in the November 2023 assembly election. Both the BJP, which won four out of the state's 17 seats in 2019, and the Congress, which won three, are looking to gain from the diminishing of the BRS, which had a tally of nine the last time round. The BJP may have missed a trick in allowing the Congress to walk away with the state in the assembly election but is putting up a hard fight now to retain the seats it won last time, and add a few more.

In Kerala, a fortress that has proved impregnable, the BJP is contesting 16 of the state's 20 seats, hoping that its double-digit vote share of 13 per cent last time converts into a seat or two. Hence, its fielding of high-profile leaders like Union minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar, relatively new faces and experimental candidates. As elsewhere, the game plan here, too, is to slowly erode support for the weaker local party—at present the Congress.

What the BJP hasn't been able to crack in the South is the salience of the regional parties. Their fierce protection of linguistic and cultural pride and articulation of people's sentiments have enabled them to grow as strong forces. The South's tradition of issue-based politics, higher conformity to the rule of law and strong assertion of federal rights vis-à-vis the Centre sync with its extra sensitivity to subjects like excessive centralisation. As the South outperforms the North on economic and social indicators, the challenges of fiscal federalism have increased and fostered the perception of a North-South divide. The South is increasingly feeling that it is not getting a fair share of benefits, given its contribution to tax revenues, a notion Modi and the BJP have been unable to dispel. If anything, their war cry of *char sau paar* has only deepened the suspicion and unease. This is what makes Mission 50 that much harder for the BJP. Will its bid to storm the South remain a pipe dream then? Weighing in on the question, psephologist and CVoter founder-director Yashwant Deshmukh says, "The BJP is poised to increase its vote share, but it may not convert into more seats. This is a long-term game for it." The next two weeks of campaigning will determine whether the party conquers the South. ■

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY